

Q I've heard that "breast is best" but what exactly is in breast milk?

Your breasts won't fill with milk until three to five days after the birth. Before that time, they contain the "pre-milk" colostrum, a highly concentrated, thick, creamy-yellow substance that has countless health benefits for your baby.

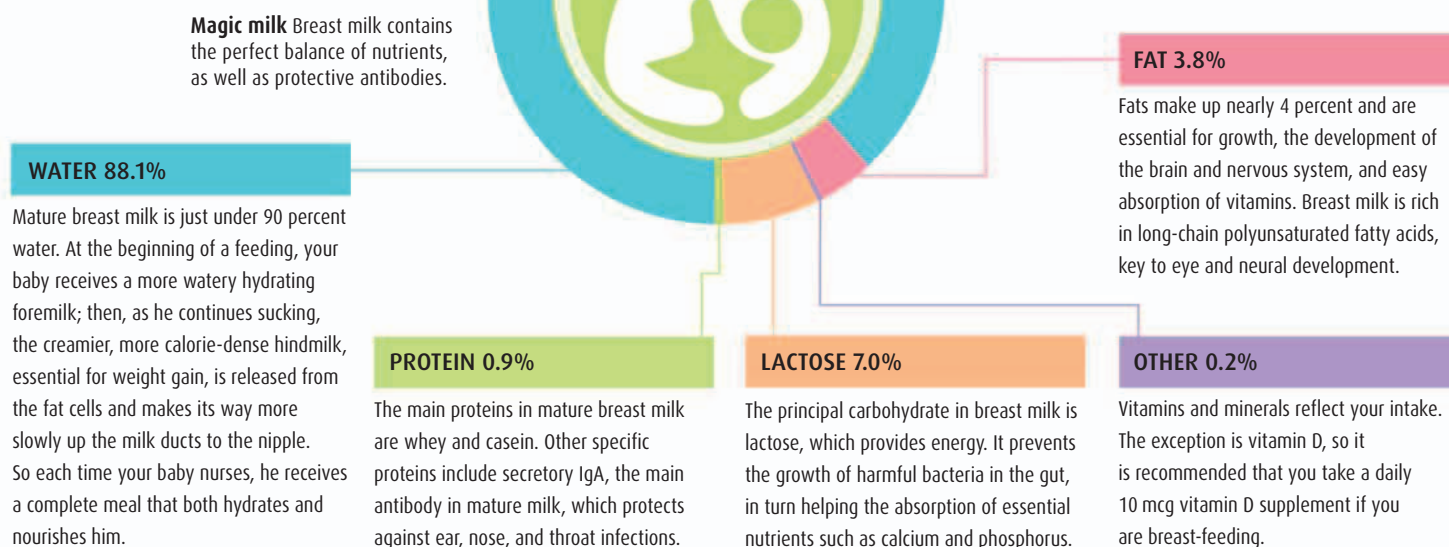
Colostrum is the perfect first food, delivering vital nutrients as well as protective antibodies that give your baby an instant immune boost. Colostrum is made in very small quantities, with your baby receiving no more than a few teaspoons worth in the first few days. This amount is exactly right for your baby, whose tiny stomach is the size of a walnut.

Colostrum is protein-rich, providing amino acids for growth and development; high in carbohydrates and fat-soluble vitamins and minerals; and low in fats, which are difficult

for your baby to digest at first. Key nutrients in colostrum are essential for the development of the brain, heart, and the central nervous system.

Colostrum provides a high concentration of disease-fighting white blood cells, and immunoglobulins that protect against germs. It also acts as a natural laxative, triggering your baby's bowels to excrete meconium (see p.247).

In addition to giving him colostrum, getting your newborn to nurse will stimulate your breasts to produce milk. The composition of breast milk is also highly remarkable, as outlined below.



Q I've been told that breast-feeding is natural, but how do I start?

If your birth is straightforward, you will be encouraged to latch your baby on right away.

Hold him skin to skin, so that he can seek out your nipple. He will do this naturally if he is given uninterrupted time. Try not to rush and remember it is a new experience for him, too. Stroke his cheek to trigger his rooting reflex, talk to him, and make eye contact. If he makes mouthing and sucking movements, gently guide him to the nipple. He may suck intermittently while he gets used to the mechanics of nursing. At birth, your baby's tiny stomach holds no more than about 1 tablespoon (15ml) of milk so he needs to be fed at regular intervals.

Q Sometimes I'm breast-feeding for an hour. How long should it take?

Breast-feedings can be anything from a few minutes to an hour or more. Once feeding is more established, you will probably find it becomes more efficient and quicker. The length may be up to the baby's temperament. While some nurse enthusiastically for a short period of time, others prefer to take it more slowly, perhaps pausing for a break midway through.

It's important that you don't limit your baby's time on the breast because that could stop him from getting the fattier, nourishing hindmilk that is released from the ducts toward the end of a feeding, which satisfies his hunger and ensures healthy growth.



Did you know...

The general guideline is that newborn babies should be fed at least eight to 12 times in a 24-hour period, with feedings given evenly throughout the day and night. If your baby is very sleepy after the birth, you may need to stir him every two to three hours to offer a feeding, stroking his cheek to stimulate his rooting reflex. Feeding frequently in these first few days allows your baby to practice latching on and sucking while your breasts are relatively empty, before your milk comes in after about three days.